

Alabama Learning Hour

Review of *-hchi*, borrowed marker *-ka*

October 1st, 2026

1 Naat̓iilka *Dialogue*

② Alabama.

Maxine: Himaakanihtaya Avaya bitkafon aayalo.

Avak illihlahchi.

Oolimpa wihlihchi.

Tanya: Oolimpa saahchon inchampolihchi?

Maxine: Avaya paspa spoyatlin inchampolihchi.

Avak Powwow-kan stinkaanomolo.

② English.

Maxine: Today Ava is at the Powwow.

Now she is hungry.

She is looking for food.

Tanya: Which food does she like?

Maxine: Ava likes frybread.

Ava really likes the Powwow.

2 Grammar

2.1 REVIEW: Present Tense: -hchi

Recall our formula for verbs in the present tense:

One-Noun Present Tense Sentence Recipe

[**Agent/Doer** + **k** **Verb** + **-hchi**]

- If we want to talk about something we are doing right now, we are doing **at this very moment**, we just add the marker -hchi in the tense slot of our template!

e.g. **Ava-k bitli-hchi** ‘Ava is dancing’

Let’s practice!

(1) hompani - to play

a. Ava is playing.

(2) illihla - to be hungry

a. Ava is hungry.

(3) waliika - to run

a. Ava is running.

(4) choffi - to jump

a. Ava is jumping.

(5) afaaka - to laugh

a. Ava is laughing.

(6) isko - to drink

a. Ava is drinking.

(7) nochi - to fall asleep

a. Ava is falling asleep.

(8) oompa - to eat

a. Ava is eating.

Asking Questions

- If you want to ask a question such as “Is Ava dancing?” all you have to do is rewrite the last **i** with a ~ on top of it and pronounce it like you have a stuffy nose!

e.g. bitli-li-hchĩ ‘Am I dancing?’

Now try (15) through (21) again, but this time asking them as questions!

More Practice!

Let’s practice with two nouns now!

Remember *-k* and *-n*?

Two-Noun Present Tense Sentence Recipe

[Doer + -k Affected + -n Verb + -hchi]

Example:

- (9) Ava-k Jacobka-n hiicha-hchi
Ava-doer Jacob-affected see-right.now.
‘Ava sees Jacob.’

Let’s practice with a partner! *How would you say this in Alabama?*

- (10) hono - skirt, choopa - buy
Q: Is Ava buying a skirt?
A: Yes (ay), Ava is buying a skirt.
- (11) bitliha - dancers, hiicha - watch
Q: Is Tanya watching the dancers?
A: Yes, Tanya is watching the dancers.
- (12) tiika - tea, isko - drink
Q: Is Ava drinking tea?
A: Yes, Ava is drinking tea.
- (13) wihli - look for
Q: Is Ava looking for Tanya?
A: Yes, Ava is looking for Tanya.
- (14) paspa spoyatli - frybread, oompa - eat
Q: Is Ava eating the frybread?
A: Yes, Ava is eating the frybread.

2.2 -ka: Using English loanwords in Alabama

- Alabama doesn't have a native word for every possible concept—especially when it comes to names, you have to change names slightly when talking about them in Alabama.
- When we want to use an English word that doesn't exist in Alabama, we do one of two things:
 1. If the English word ends in a 'light syllable' that sounds like 'uh' (example: Tanya, Ava, Micah, Sarah) we do nothing!
 2. If it ends in an -er sound, like in Peter, Alexander, (even if it's not spelled that way, like in *wire*), we pronounce it like we were British and replace the -er with a 'uh' sound:
Peter → /piita/
Alexander → /aleksanda/
brother → /braʔa/
sister → /sista/
wire → /waya/
 3. Otherwise, we add -ka to the end of the word!
Powwow → powwow-ka
Jacob → Jacob-ka
Jackson → Jackson-ka

★ Every language uses loanwords! It's completely natural to use English words in Alabama: All the elders do it!

★ English has loanwords too! Did you know that the word Beef is a French word? And Barbecue is a word from the Taíno tribe? Even Texas is a loanword!

★ Sometimes, even when there's an Alabama word, people will still use the English loanword!

☞ Some people will say “frybread-ka” instead of *paspa spoyatli* or “sista” instead of *ifoni* (for men) or *chaachi* (for women).

★ So don't feel bad about using English loanwords in Alabama. If there's no better way to express yourself, sometimes you have to!

Let's practice! *How would you say these names in Alabama?*

(15) James

(16) Emma

(17) Daniel

(18) Alice

(19) Oliver

3 Vocabulary

Nouns

Powwow-Related

aabitka	dancing ground
bokoko	drum
bitka	dance
bitliha	dancers
chassi bitka	corn dance
chokfi bitka	rabbit dance
isbitka holikfa	regalia/clothes for dancing
hono	skirt
Powwow-ka	Powwow

Food & Drink

nipo	meat
oolimpa	food
paspa spoyatli	frybread
tiika (champoli)	(sweet) tea
yakchi	yakchi

Date & Time

himaaka nihta	today
piyaaka	yesterday

Verbs

Ka-Verbs

afaaka	to laugh
isko	to drink

Li-Verbs

bokoko batli
bitli
chiyahli
ilakomayli
sahmi
wihli
inchampoli

to beat/hit drums
to dance
to walk
to swim
to happen how? be like what?
to look for
to like the taste of

Simple-Verbs

aaya
choopa
hiicha
hompani
ittanowwa
inhaalo
okchakko
oompa
illihla
stinkaano

to be located/around (for one or two people)
to buy
to see/watch
to play
to be located/around (for multiple people)
to listen to someone/somebody
to be blue
to eat
to be hungry
to like